MOREH NEVUCHIM

The Creation Narrative Reexamined: What Adam Truly Lost

Given Tuesday 19 May 2026 · Moreh Nevuchim Chapters 1-2

Sefer: Moreh Nebuchim (The Guide for the Perplexed) — Rambam **Section:** Completing Chapter 1 · Beginning Chapter 2 **Topic:** Tzelem & Demut · The Creation Narrative Reexamined **Text:** Sefaria edition (Rabbi Chaim Makbili's modern Hebrew translation from the Arabic)

Why This Shiur Matters

We are approaching Shavuot 5786 — the festival whose essence is Torah. Tonight Rambam will give us **a whole new understanding of Bereishit** that we read every year since childhood.

Dayan Lopian z"l once said: "The older I get, the less I understand Bereishit."

This evening's mission: finish Chapter 1 (the meaning of *tzelem* and *demut*), then begin Chapter 2 — where Rambam takes apart and reconstructs the entire story of Gan Eden.

Recap from Last Week

Section 1 Structure (76 Chapters)

- **Chapters 1-49:** Refuting any physical conception of Hashem; explaining anthropomorphic language
- **Chapters 50-69:** Negative theology — God can only be described in negations
- **Chapters 70-76:** Against the Mutakallimun (Islamic theological philosophers)

The Opening of Chapter 1

- The verse נעשה אדם בצלמנו כדמותנו led people to corporealism
- They reasoned: we can't deny the pesukim, so God must have some physical form
- Even the "refined" version (bigger than human, more luminous, not flesh and blood) is still corporealism — and the Rambam will reject it equally
- **Shiur Komah** — that strange text with measurements of God's body — Rambam explicitly rejected in Teshuvah 117 ("a great mitzvah to erase this book")
- Corporealism doesn't just contradict Hashem's nature — it contradicts His **unity**

The Vocabulary Foundation — Three Words

Word	Meaning
Toar	Physical form / bodily features
Tzelem	Essence — the defining nature that makes something what it is
Demut	Similarity / resemblance (not identity)

What We Established About Toar

- Yosef: יפה תואר ויפה מראה — beautiful in form and appearance
- Shaul asking the medium about Shmuel: מה תארו — *"what is his form?"*
- Gideon: כתאר בני המלך — like the bearing of royalty
- Crafting: יתארהו בשרד — forming with marker and compass

המונח הזה אינו חל על אלוקות חלילה וחס

***Toar* is NEVER applied to Hashem in Tanakh.** Because *toar* means physical form, and Hashem has no physical form, the Torah's vocabulary itself respects His incorporeality.

PART 1 — Completing Chapter 1: Tzelem and Demut

Defining Tzelem

ואילו צלם חל על הצורה הטבעית, כלומר על העניין המגדיר את עצמותו של דבר ועושה אותו למה שהוא, והוא מהותו האמיתית באשר הוא מצוי זה

***Tzelem* describes the natural form of a thing — the matter that defines its essence and makes it what it is, its true essence as that which exists.**

In other words: tzelem = **essence**, not body.

What Is the Tzelem of a Human?

ועניין זה הצלם אצל האדם הוא מה שבאמצעותו תתבצע ההשגה האנושית

The tzelem of a human is what enables human apprehension — intellectual capacity.

What makes a human a human? Not the shape of the body (we share that with mammals). It is **the rational faculty** — the capacity for intellect, abstraction, reason.

בשל אותה השגה שכלית נאמר עליו בצלם אלוהים ברא אותו

That is what the verse means when it says man was created *b'tzelem Elokim*: Hashem has intellect, and humans share — at the deepest level — this same essential property of intellect.

(Of course Hashem's intellect and human intellect are radically different. We will see how the word *demut* handles this.)

Proof 1 (Clear): Tehillim — צלמם תבזה

David HaMelech in Tehillim:

> כחלום מהקיץ, ה' בעיר צלמם תבזה — *"Like a dream upon awakening, when Hashem arises, He will despise their tzelem"*

The Question

When Hashem despises wicked people, does He despise their face, eyes, and body? Of course not. **He despises their essence — their wicked character.**

The Proof

כי ביזיון שייך לנפש שהוא צורת המין, לא לתבנית האיברים ומתארם

Contempt is directed at the soul (the form of the species), not at the bodily structure.

When the verse says Hashem will despise their *tzelem*, **tzelem must mean their inner essence**, not their physical form. This is a clean, decisive proof for Rambam's definition.

Proof 2 (Apparent Counter-Example): Idols Are Called Tzelamim

In Tanakh, idols are called *tzelamim*. Surely this proves *tzelem* means physical form?

Rambam's Answer

וכך אני אומר שהפסלים נקראו צלמים משום שהמבוקש מהם היה העניין שיחסו להם, לא לתבניתם ומתארם

Idols are called *tzelamim* because of the concept attributed to them — not because of their physical structure.

The Key Insight (Chapter 36 Preview)

Even the greatest idolater never believed in the essential quality of the wood or metal itself.

The idolater wasn't worshipping the wood. He was worshipping **what the idol represented** — the supernatural connection it embodied, the transcendence it pointed to. The wood was a vehicle for a concept.

So *tzelem* still means **essence/concept**, even in the idolatry context — the essence being supernatural connection.

Proof 3 (Hardest Counter-Example): Tzalmei Techoreichem

The Philistines, plagued for seven months after capturing the Aron, were told to return it with a guilt offering: **חמשה טחורי זהב** — five golden hemorrhoids. The next verse says:

ועשיתם **צלמי טחוריכם**

"And you shall make tzalmei techoreichem (images/forms of your hemorrhoids)"

The simple reading: they made literal physical images of hemorrhoids. This seems to give *tzelem* a purely physical meaning.

Rambam's Answer

עניין הרחקת פגע הטחורים, לא לתבנית הטחורים

The verse refers to the concept of repudiating the plague of hemorrhoids — not the physical shape of hemorrhoids.

Two Possible Readings of Rambam's Position

Reading 1	Reading 2
They did NOT make literal hemorrhoid forms; they made *something* whose function was to dispel the plague. *Tzelem* = the concept.	They DID make physical hemorrhoid icons, but the *tzelem* refers to what those icons concept-fully represent — the plague itself, which they sought to dispel.

If You Insist on Physical Meaning

Rambam offers a fallback:

ואם יכריח הוא שצלמי טחוריכם וצלמים נקראים ככה לשם התבניות והמצרים, יהיה צלם מונח רב משמעות ומשותף

If you insist that here *tzelem* means physical form — fine. Then *tzelem* is a multi-meaning word: sometimes essence (Tehillim), sometimes physical form (these cases). But in Bereishit:

ויהיה המכוון בדבריו נעשה אדם בצלמנו: הוא ההשגה שכלית, לא התבנית המצרית

The intent in "let us make man in our tzelem" is intellectual apprehension — NOT physical form, since God has no physical form to share with us.

The Rambam wins either way:

- *Tzelem* always means essence (preferred reading), OR
- *Tzelem* is multi-meaning, but specifically in Bereishit it means intellect

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Defining Demut

ואלו דמות הוא מונח הנגזר מדמה — וגם הוא דמות בניין עניין

***Demut* derives from *domeh* (similar) — denoting similarity in concept, not identity.**

This is a *crucial* distinction: *demut* means **resembling**, not **being identical to**.

Proofs for Demut as Conceptual Similarity

Proof 1 — דמיתי לקאת מדבר

David in Tehillim: *"I am like (damiti) the pelican of the desert"*

לא באו לומר שהוא דומה בכנפיה ובראשה, אלא שיגונו דומה ליגונה

He doesn't mean he has wings and a beak like a pelican. He means his pain and loneliness resemble the pelican's loneliness in the desert. *(Saadia Gaon explicitly explains the pelican as the lonely desert bird.)*

Proof 2 — כל עץ בגן אלוהים לא דמה אליו ביפיו

Yechezkel comparing Ashur to the trees of the Garden:

"No tree in the garden of God was like it in its beauty"

Comparing a country to trees obviously isn't a physical similarity — it's a similarity **in beauty as a concept**.

Proof 3 — חמת למו כדמות חמת נחש

"Their venom is like the venom of a snake"

David isn't saying Hashem will literally bring snakes to bite the wicked. The *concept* of snake venom — dangerous, deadly — is what is being compared.

Proof 4 — דמיונו כאריה יכסוף לטרוף

"His image is like a lion eager to tear"

The wicked are like predatory lions — not in physical form, but **in concept** (waiting to attack the innocent).

Proof 5 — דמות הכסא (Yechezkel's vision)

"An image of a throne"

דמות בעניין הרוממות והנכבדות, לא בריבועו וגובהו ורוחב רגליו כמו שחושבים הפתאים

Similar to a throne in its elevation and majesty — not in its square shape, height, and leg-width "as the foolish think." Yechezkel saw an elevated, majestic presence — not a literal piece of furniture.

Proof 6 — דמות החיות (the angels)

"An image of the living beings"

Above the angels was something **resembling** a throne — meaning elevated and majestic, not a literal throne.

Now Putting It Together — נעשה אדם בצלמנו כדמותנו

The Verse Means

וכיון שהאדם מתייחד בענין מופלא מאוד שבו, שאינו קיים בדבר מן הנמצאים תחת גלגל הירח, והיא ההשגה השכלית שאינה משתמשת לא בחוש ולא בגופים

Since humans are uniquely distinguished by something extraordinary — found in no other creature under the heavens — namely intellectual apprehension that uses neither senses nor bodily organs...

(Why "under the heavens"? Because Rambam holds — like many medieval Rishonim — that celestial bodies possess their own intellect. The phrase delimits the comparison to terrestrial creatures.)

The Similarity to God

דמתה אותה להשגת האלוה

This non-bodily intellect resembles God's intellect — which also uses no physical organ.

But — Similar, Not Identical

אף שאין זו דמות באמת אלא במבט הראשון בלבד

It is not a true resemblance, only at the first glance — because, as Yeshayahu says:

"My thoughts are not your thoughts" — לא מחשבותי מחשבותיכם

(Rambam uses this verse extensively to explain how Hashem's foreknowledge is compatible with human free will — His knowing is categorically different from ours.)

Why "Resemblance" Then?

Even though our intellect is radically different from Hashem's, **it is the closest resemblance possible.** Of all created things, the human's intellectual faculty is what most approximates God's nature — therefore the verse uses *demut*.

Chapter 1 — Concluding Statement

ובשל אותו עניין, כלומר השכל הדבוק בו, נאמר לאדם שהוא בצלם אלהים ובדמותו, לא שהאל יתעלה הוא גוף

Because of this — the intellect that adheres to the human — the verse says man is in God's image and likeness — NOT that God Himself has a body.

The Full Vocabulary Now Resolved

Word	Meaning	Applied to Humans
Toar	Physical form	Used (Yosef, etc.); never used of God
Tzelem	Essence	The intellectual faculty
Demut	Resemblance (not identity)	We resemble God in having intellect, though our intellect is categorically lower

Jonathan's Beautiful Observation in the Shiur

"It seems Rambam is dematerializing avodah zarah while corporealists are materializing God — moving in opposite directions but with the same misconception about essence and form."

The Rambam confirms this is correct. The idolater materializes the divine; the corporealist materializes God. Both are reading *tzelem* as physical when it really means essence.

PART 2 — Beginning Chapter 2: The Creation Narrative Reexamined

We now leave the simple vocabulary discussion and enter what Rambam calls a **digression** — but it is **the** most profound digression in the early chapters of the Moreh. The discussion of

tzelem raises a question about Bereishit that **changes how we read the entire creation narrative**.

We will not finish this chapter tonight. There is enormous depth here. We will spend most of next week's shiur on it.

The Setup — Three Meanings of "Elohim"

Before stating the question, Rambam needs us to know that **Elohim is a polysemous (multi-meaning) word** in Hebrew with three distinct meanings:

Meaning 1 — God

The most common usage.

Meaning 2 — Angels (Malachim)

כי ה' אלוקיכם הוא אלהי האלהים — *"For Hashem your God is the God of gods"* (Eikev)

The Torah doesn't condone other gods. So "*Elohei ha'Elohim*" must mean: **the God of the angels.** Here *Elohim* = angels.

Meaning 3 — Judges or Important People

עד האלהים יבא דבר שניהם — *"The case shall come before the Elohim"* (Mishpatim)

Here it clearly refers to **human judges** — those of standing and authority.

Onkelos on והייתם כאלוהים יודעי טוב ורע

In the seduction by the serpent:

ביום אכלכם ממנו ונפקחו עיניכם **והייתם כאלהים** יודעי טוב ורע

"You will be like Elohim, knowing good and evil"

Onkelos translates this as:

ותהון **כרברבין** חכימין בין טב לביש

"You will be like *rabbis/great ones* — wise (or discerning) between good and bad."

Onkelos chooses **Meaning 3** — important/prominent people. **NOT** "like gods" (a common but wrong translation).

This is critical. *If you don't take Onkelos's interpretation seriously, the rest of Rambam's argument falls apart.*

The "Astonishing Question" — Posed by a Learned Person

The Rambam describes the question as:

קושיא מופלאה *(Arabic: ghariba — strange/wondrous/deep)*

A question worthy of careful examination.

The Question Stated

Reading the simple peshat of Bereishit:

1. **Chapter 1 (creation):** Man is created *b'tzelem Elokim* — which we just learned means with intellect.
2. **Chapter 3 (the sin):** The serpent says — *"on the day you eat, you will be like Elohim, knowing good and evil."* And the verse says after they ate, **their eyes were opened and they realized they were naked.**

The peshat seems to imply: **the human's faculty for distinguishing good and evil came only AFTER the sin.**

The Contradiction with Chapter 1

If the human had full intellect (tzelem Elokim) in Chapter 1, why does the snake offer "knowledge" as if it's something new in Chapter 3?

The Even Sharper Question

The intellect to distinguish good and evil is **what makes a human a human** — the very essence we just established. But here:

שהעונש על החטא הזה מתן שלמות שלא היתה לו

The "punishment" for the sin is the granting of a perfection the human didn't have before!

This is bewildering. Why would Hashem **reward** a sin with the granting of the human's defining essence?

The Rambam compares this absurdity to:

"It's like saying: a person sinned and was rewarded by being turned into a star in the heavens"

— a reference to **Greek mythology** (likely Orion the hunter), which the Rambam dismisses as nonsense.

Rambam's Rebuke Before Answering

אתה מעיין בירורים ראשונים ומחשבות מזדמנות... כמו שעובר על אחד מספרי ההיסטוריה או אחד מן השירים

"You investigate based on your first superficial thoughts. You want to understand a book that has guided generations as if you're reading it in your spare time between meals and entertainment — like a history book or a poem."

The Rambam is unimpressed with the questioner despite earlier calling him "learned." The question is real, but the questioner approaches Torah carelessly.

"Pay attention to my answer — it is not what you think on first glance."

Rambam's Answer — Premise 1: Man Had Full Intellect in Chapter 1

שהשכל שהשם השפיע על האדם והוא שלמותו האחרונה הוא שקיבל האדם לפני חטאו

The intellect that Hashem bestowed upon man — which is his ultimate perfection — was received before his sin.

This intellect:

- Was complete from creation
- Was what made commanding him possible (you don't command beings without intellect)
- Is referenced when the verse says he was created *b'tzelem Elokim*

ולגבי השכל נאמר על אדם שבצלמנו כדמותנו נעשה

Because of this intellect, the verse says he was created in our *tzelem* (essence) — which we just learned means intellect.

Note Against Mark's Suggestion in the Shiur

Mark suggested: maybe man was given a *lower* level of intellect in Chapter 1 and a *higher* level after eating from the tree.

Rambam explicitly rejects this. The human had **full** intellect from the start — not partial. The change wasn't quantitative.

So what DID change?

Rambam's Answer — Premise 2: There Are TWO Different Domains of Knowledge

This is the bomb. Pay close attention:

ובשכל מבחינים בין האמת לבין השקר, וזה לאדם אופן מושלם

Through intellect we distinguish between *truth and falsehood* — and in this man was perfectly equipped from the start.

BUT:

הגנאי והנאה הוא מן המפורסמות, לא מן המוסכלות

Good (na'eh) and bad (mguneh) are not in the domain of intellect — they belong to the realm of social consensus (mefursamot), not to intellectual truth.

The Crucial Distinction Rambam Is Making

Domain	Type of Knowledge	Examples
Muskalot (intellectual truths)	Objective — true or false	"The sky is blue." "World War II ended in 1945." "Two plus two equals four." "The earth orbits the sun."
Mefursamot (social consensus)	Subjective — good or bad	"Nudity is shameful." "Honor your elders." Most norms of ethical behavior in contexts where it isn't basic murder/theft.

משום שאין אומרים השמים כדוריים נאה, והארץ שטוחה מגונה — אלא אומרים אמת או שקר

We don't say "the sky is spherical is good" or "the earth is flat is bad" — we say "true" or "false." Because these are facts.

וכן בלשוננו יאמר על הנכון ועל הכזב אמת ושקר, ועל המגונה טוב ורע, ובשכל מכיר האדם את האמת והשקר, וכך הוא בכל הדברים השכליים

Even in our language: for facts we say true/false; for moral/aesthetic things we say good/bad. Intellect handles truth and falsehood — and works the same way for all intellectual matters.

The Implication — The Bombshell

Here is the framework Rambam is setting up:

Before the Sin

The human had **full intellect** — which works in the domain of **truth and falsehood**.

In Gan Eden, the human saw the world purely objectively:

- True / False
- Real / Unreal
- Existent / Non-existent

Good and bad simply weren't categories that defined his experience. Everything in Gan Eden was *tov me'od* — there was no domain of "good and bad" to navigate. The intellect didn't need it.

After the Sin

The human gained access to a *new* domain — the domain of **mefursamot, social/subjective good and bad**.

This is **not** an upgrade of intellect. It's the acquisition of a *different kind of knowing* — a more subjective, blurry, conventional kind of knowing.

The Question About Nudity (To Be Developed Next Week)

Before the sin: nudity is just a fact — true (we are naked). The human had no embarrassment because embarrassment is a *mefursamot* concept ("nakedness is bad") that requires the social-good-and-bad faculty.

After the sin: the human acquires the faculty of *mefursamot* and immediately realizes "nakedness is bad" — and is ashamed.

This is why the verse says *"and their eyes were opened, and they knew they were naked."* They didn't gain new vision. They didn't gain new intellect. They gained the faculty of subjective moral/aesthetic judgment that the original intellect did not include.

Jonathan's Important Observation (To Be Developed)

"It seems like Rambam is talking about the difference between an 'is' and an 'ought' proposition — descriptive statements vs. normative ones."

Exactly right. This is precisely the distinction:

- **Is propositions** (descriptive): handled by intellect → truth/falsehood

- **Ought propositions** (normative): handled by mefursamot → good/bad

In modern philosophical terms, the Rambam is making a fact/value distinction — and saying the original human inhabited the world of facts (the world of *is*), and only after the sin began to inhabit the world of values (the world of *ought*).

The Rambam, following Aristotle, holds that ethics belong to the realm of norms (subjective social agreement) — **not** to the realm of objective intellectual truth. This is a profoundly modern philosophical position embedded in his reading of Bereishit.

Why the "Punishment" Was Actually a Loss

The questioner thought the sin was rewarded with intellect. **The Rambam is reversing the entire reading:**

- **Before:** Pure intellectual existence — engaging with reality as *is* / *is not*
- **After:** Forced into the realm of *should* / *shouldn't*, conventional social norms, embarrassment, shame, the subjective

The "punishment" wasn't a gain — it was a **descent** from a higher mode of being (pure intellectual engagement with truth) to a lower mode of being (entanglement with social good-and-bad).

The "opening of the eyes" was a regression in this sense — not an elevation.

Where We Stop — Setup for Next Week

We have laid out:

1. The completed definitions of toar, tzelem, and demut
2. The question on Bereishit
3. The vocabulary needed (three meanings of Elohim; Onkelos on "like Elohim")
4. The opening of the answer — that the human had full intellect from the start
5. The bombshell — there are TWO domains of knowledge (muskalot and mefursamot)

Coming Up Next Week

- **Full development of the answer:** How did the sin specifically cause the shift from muskalot to mefursamot?
- **What was the serpent actually offering?**
- **The clothing, the shame, the nakedness — all reread through this framework**
- **The deeper meaning** of *"their eyes were opened"*
- **What the Tree of Knowledge of Good and Evil really represents**
- This will likely take the entire next shiur

After Chapter 2 we will return to the vocabulary project — explaining many more multi-meaning Hebrew terms in Tanakh.

Tonight's Summary

Chapter 1 (Complete):

- Toar = physical form (never used of God)
- Tzelem = essence (used of God's likeness in man = intellect)
- Demut = resemblance, not identity (we resemble God only at first glance — our intellects are categorically different)

Chapter 2 (Begun):

- The Bereishit question is real and profound
- The answer involves recognizing two distinct domains of knowledge:
- Muskalot — intellect — true/false — objective
- Mefursamot — social consensus — good/bad — subjective
- Man had FULL intellect before the sin
- The sin caused not an intellectual upgrade but a **transition** from pure intellectual existence to a more subjective, norm-bound existence
- The "opening of the eyes" is a *descent*, not an *ascent*

Chag Sameach · Have a wonderful Shavuot

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